

Canada Study Permit Guide

Visa Type

A Study Permit is the official document issued by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) allowing foreign nationals to study at Designated Learning Institutions (DLIs) in Canada for programs longer than 6 months.

Required Documents

- Valid passport
- Letter of Acceptance from a Designated Learning Institution (DLI)
- Proof of financial support covering tuition and living expenses
- A letter of explanation or statement of purpose
- Proof of ties to home country, such as family, property, or employment
- Language test results such as IELTS, TOEFL, or TEF
- Academic transcripts and certificates
- Results of an immigration medical examination, if required
- Police clearance certificates, if required
- Biometrics, fingerprints and photograph

Financial Requirements

Applicants must show proof of funds covering full first-year tuition plus approximately 10,000 CAD in living expenses for provinces outside Quebec, or around 11,000 CAD within Quebec. An additional 4,000 CAD is required for each accompanying family member. Many applicants from eligible countries use the Student Direct Stream (SDS), which requires a Guaranteed Investment Certificate (GIC) of 10,200 CAD purchased from a participating Canadian bank.

Processing Time

Standard processing typically takes 8 to 12 weeks, though times vary significantly by country of residence. The Student Direct Stream offers faster processing, often around 20 business days, for eligible applicants from countries such as India, China, the Philippines, and others who meet language and financial requirements.

Application Steps

- Receive a Letter of Acceptance from a Designated Learning Institution
- Confirm your institution appears on the official DLI list
- Create an account on the IRCC online portal
- Complete and submit the study permit application along with supporting documents
- Pay the study permit processing fee, currently 150 CAD

- Pay the biometrics fee, currently 85 CAD, valid for 10 years
- Complete a medical exam if requested by an IRCC panel physician
- Wait for a decision; additional documents may be requested
- Receive a Port of Entry Letter and obtain the physical study permit upon arrival in Canada

Interview Requirements

Most study permit applicants are not required to attend an in-person interview, though IRCC may request one at a Canadian visa office or embassy in certain cases, particularly where additional clarification is needed.

Work Rights

Study permit holders may work up to 20 hours per week off campus during regular academic sessions and full time during scheduled breaks such as winter and summer holidays, provided the program is at least 6 months long and leads to a degree, diploma, or certificate.

Common FAQs

- What is a DLI? A Designated Learning Institution is a school approved by a provincial or territorial government to host international students under a valid study permit.
- What is a GIC? A Guaranteed Investment Certificate is a savings product purchased from a participating Canadian bank, used to demonstrate funds under the Student Direct Stream.
- Can I work after graduating? Many graduates are eligible for a Post-Graduation Work Permit (PGWP) valid for up to 3 years, depending on the length of their study program.